Whose Neighborhood Now?
Gentrification and Community Life in Low-Income Urban Neighborhoods

by

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CES 24-29 June 2024

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Abstract

Gentrification is a process of urban change that has wide-ranging social and political impacts, but previous studies provide divergent findings. Does gentrification leave residents feeling alienated, or does it bolster neighborhood social satisfaction? Politically, does urban change mobilize residents, or leave them disengaged? I assess a national, cross-sectional sample of about 17,500 respondents in lower-income urban neighborhoods, and use a structural equation modeling approach to model six latent variables pertaining to local social environment and political participation. Amongst the full sample, gentrification has a positive association with all six factors. However, this relationship depends upon respondents' level of income, length of residency, and racial identity. White residents and those with shorter length of residency report higher levels of social cohesion as gentrification increases, but there is no such association amongst racial minority groups and longer-term residents. This finding aligns with a perspective on gentrification as a racialized process, and demonstrates that gentrification-related amenities primarily serve the interests of white residents and newcomers. All groups, however, are more likely to participate in neighborhood politics as gentrification increases, drawing attention to the agency of local residents as they attempt to influence processes of urban change.

[*] Any views expressed are those of the authors and not those of the U.S. Census Bureau. The Census Bureau has reviewed this data product to ensure appropriate access, use, and disclosure avoidance protection of the confidential source data used to produce this product. This research was performed at a Federal Statistical Research Data Center under FSRDC Project Number 2689. (CBDRB-FY24-0223)

Introduction

In cities across the United States, gentrification is a bitterly contested issue. *Gentrification* typically refers to the process by which urban neighborhoods experience capital investment and the in-migration of relatively well-off individuals (Smith 1998:198), leading to concerns over pricing out or otherwise displacing incumbent residents (Marcuse 1986; Newman & Wyly 2006). Many insist, however, that this process is not *only* about housing. Activists, journalists, and academics claim that gentrification is a social and cultural process as well; that it invariably alters a neighborhood's character and social environment such that residents who have lived in the area for a long time now feel out of place and unwelcome.

Within the scholarly literature, however, there remains a methodological divide when it comes to investigating gentrification's impacts (Brown-Saracino 2017). Broadly speaking, quantitative scholars have largely attempted to track physical displacement, or involuntary changes in residence (Carlson 2020), that occur due to gentrification. Qualitative studies, on the other hand, are more likely to focus on gentrification as a social and cultural process – with conflicting results. On one hand, many ethnographers argue that even when residents in gentrifying areas are not forced from their homes, they may still face the loss of local institutions, political power, social networks, and community norms of interaction (Betancur 2011; Davidson 2008; Helmuth 2019; Hyra 2017; Martin 2007; Wynne and Rogers 2021). As opposed to a process of physical uprooting, social displacement refers to a feeling of alienation and isolation wrought by this transformation (Chernoff 1980), while political displacement refers to the supplanting of local organizing blocs in favor of new coalitions (Hyra 2017; Martin 2007). On the other hand, some scholars downplay the social-political displacement perspective, and suggest that the amenities that often accompany gentrification, like a reduction in crime, may actually allow residents to socialize more freely

(Freeman 2006). Politically, some researchers argue that the threats and opportunities presented by gentrification actually spur residents to mobilize in order to resist neighborhood change, protect local cultural practices and institutions, or otherwise attempt to augment the process (Betancur 2002; Summers 2021).

In this paper, I respond to critical points of uncertainty within the gentrification literature by bridging this methodological divide. I quantitatively test the relationship between gentrification and community life to answer two questions. Socially, does gentrification leave residents feeling isolated and unwelcome, or does it tend to bolster satisfaction with their social environment? Politically, does gentrification mobilize residents to get involved in local problem-solving efforts, or leave them disengaged? I answer these questions through a quantitative evaluation of a large, cross-sectional sample of residents living in lower-income urban neighborhoods undergoing varying degrees of gentrification-related changes in demographics and investment. Based on the responses of about 17,500 residents[1] across the United States, I create a series of 6 latent variable constructs that measure various aspects of neighborhood *social environment* and *participation*. Using a multi-group structural equation modeling (SEM) approach, I observe the associations between the degree of gentrification and the 6 latent variables.

Amongst the full sample, I find a positive association between neighborhood gentrification and all of the social environment and participation variables. To add additional nuance to these initial findings, however, I use multi-group SEM analysis to observe the results amongst respondent groups split up by income, length of residency, and racial self-identification. Lower-income groups demonstrate a stronger positive correlation between the social environment variables and gentrification. This could be due to higher baseline levels of social satisfaction

[1] Due to Census Bureau disclosure requirement, I must report rounded entity counts rather than exact numbers. Throughout the paper, I use the tilde symbol (~) to indicate approximate counts.

amongst higher-income groups. These associations are also much stronger amongst white residents and those who have lived in their home for shorter amounts of time. In fact, positive relationships between gentrification and the social environment variables virtually disappear amongst racial minority Black and Latinx groups. In terms of community politics, almost all groups – regardless of social location – report higher levels of participation as gentrification intensifies.

From these results I draw three contributions to research on the social problem of neighborhood gentrification. First, I find general support for the political mobilization perspective: residents in gentrifying areas tend to be more involved in shaping neighborhood affairs than their peers in non-gentrifying areas. This finding draws attention to the agency of local residents as they respond to neighborhood change. Second, I do not find support for the social displacement perspective, and argue that concentrated neighborhood poverty and urban decline appear to be more socially deleterious than gentrification. Third, however, my models do demonstrate that the extent to which gentrification serves as a social amenity depends largely on social location – particularly along racial lines. These results strengthen the perspective that gentrification is a process of racial capitalism (Rucks-Ahidiana 2022) that primarily serves the tastes of recent in-movers and white residents (Danley and Weaver 2018; Golio 2024; Hyra 2017; Kirkland 2008; Smith 1996; Summers 2019; Torres 2020).

Literature Review

I. *The Social and Political Impacts of Gentrification*

Gentrification has grown widely in scope and attention over the last half-century. As a widespread contemporary urban phenomenon, it is imperative that we understand the full scope of gentrification's impacts. To this end, quantitative researchers have mostly debated whether gentrification is associated with physical displacement. On this question, the field is famously split,

with some scholars finding a lack of evidence of coerced relocation (Ding, Hwang, and Divringi 2016; Dragan, Gould Ellen, and Glied 2020; Freeman 2005) while others find the opposite (Marcuse 1986; Newman and Wyly 2006; Raymond et al. 2021). With few clear answers on the question of physical displacement, scholars are left to ponder other ways in which gentrification might impact a community and its long-standing residents.

Ethnographic studies emphasize that gentrification holds enormous potential to disrupt the social 'fabric' of incumbent communities (Betancur 2011), as new middle- and upper-class residents – and their influence on the landscape – leave incumbent working-class populations feeling isolated. This process is sometimes termed social displacement (Chernoff 1980; for variations see Davidson 2008; Hyra 2017; Wynne and Rogers 2021); it refers not to the loss of a physical dwelling, but of meaningful community life. Scholars argue that even when physical displacement does not occur, residents' affective connections to place can still be disrupted (Elliott-Cooper, Hubbard, and Lees 2019). Gentrifiers bring to their new neighborhoods unique tastes, patterns of behavior, and normative expectations that form the basis of social boundaries that tend to exclude and alienate incumbent residents, particularly along class lines (Danley and Weaver 2018; Centner 2008; Tissot 2011).

Commercial spaces turn over to meet these new demands, leading to the closure of gathering spots that facilitate the formation and strengthening of social ties and cohesion amongst incumbent residents (Hyra 2017; Torres 2020). Local businesses also serve as highly visible symbols of neighborhood character and symbolic ownership (Deener 2012) – therefore, commercial turnover might cause incumbent residents to feel that the area is no longer 'for them' (Ocejo 2014; Torres 2020; Tuttle 2022). Most studies are primary concerned with 'old-timers' (Brown-Saracino 2009), or long-time neighborhood residents, and their feeling that gentrification-

related development is not built for their social needs, but rather those of newcomers (Danley and Weaver 2018). Also, these shifts to the urban landscape tend to be geared toward middle- and upper-class tastes and sensibilities, leaving the working class with fewer options for socializing and recreation (Centner 2008; Ocejo 2014; Smith 1996; Torres 2020; Zukin 2010). Therefore, we might expect that gentrification will have a more acutely negative social impact lower-income individuals.

Though not as widely argued, other research findings suggest that gentrification can strengthen or improve community life for long-time residents. Some may enjoy the new commercial options and public amenities that open during the gentrification process (Freeman 2006), prompting them to engage more with their surroundings. Given that gentrification occurs in historically disinvested neighborhoods (Smith 1998:98), some degree of development may be a welcome sight to some residents (Freeman 2006; Holt et al. 2021). Also, criminologists find that gentrification is associated with a modest reduction in neighborhood crime rates (Barton 2016; Papachristos et al. 2011), which may allow residents to more safely and freely interact. Finally, as Brown-Saracino (2009) points out, many gentrifiers act as 'social preservationists,' who try very intentionally *not* to disrupt the existing social fabric, and take various actions to make sure that old-timers and their institutions remain in place.

Turning from the social to the political, there are similarly divergent perspectives on the relationship between gentrification and residents' participation in local problem-solving efforts. Similar to social displacement, the concept of political displacement refers to a loss of decision-making power and general influence for incumbent neighborhood groups (Hyra 2017; Martin 2007). Political displacement is not just about being outvoted by newer resident coalitions – as some scholars attest, gentrification may also be accompanied by a retreat from public participation

on the part of long-time residents (Hyra 2017; Knotts and Haspel 2006; Newman, Velez, and Pearson-Merkowitz 2016). As the addition of gentrifiers and capital investment disrupts local institutions and replaces cultural norms, long-standing residents may withdraw from public life (Hyra 2017; Kozey 2020; Newman, Velez, and Pearson-Merkowitz 2016).

Other scholars, however, document residents' political engagement in issues surrounding local development, suggesting that gentrification may actually spur responsive mobilization. Much of this research focuses on resistance to housing cost increases, predatory financialization, and threats to local cultural practices and institutions (Curran 2018; Martinez 2010; Perez 2004; Robinson 1995; Summers 2021; Summers and Fields 2022). Scholars also recognize that residents and institutions are not only involved in resisting gentrification but also facilitating it or seeking to profit from it (Betancur 2002; Hyra 2008). Regardless of their aims, this literature inspires a sense that neighborhood residents are not bystanders to processes of urban change, but seek to get involved.

Parsing amongst these conflicting perspectives – social displacement vs. social amenity, political displacement vs. political mobilization – it is useful to systematically examine the relationship between gentrification and community life on a national, cross-sectional level. Some previous quantitative attempts have approached the issue, but remain limited either to a specific metropolitan context or to a particular aspect of social life (Butler and Robson 2001; Knotts and Haspel 2006; Kozey 2020; Newman, Velez, and Pearson-Merkowitz 2016; Versey 2018). I contribute a more encompassing consideration of a neighborhood's social and political environment across virtually all large American cities.

II. *Gentrification and Stratification by Race and Class*

Gentrification is not a single process that plays out evenly across social groups; rather, it interacts with existing landscapes of inequality to produce disparate manifestations and impacts. Similarly to social class, scholars have also long identified racial stratification within gentrifying neighborhoods. Residents of color – particularly those who are Black and Latinx – often experience more acutely the gentrification-related feelings of exclusion, alienation, and stress explained earlier (Helmuth 2019; Holt et al. 2021; Summers 2019). Often, gentrification involves not only class turnover, but also shifting racial dynamics. Due to the historic and contemporary relationship amongst race, wealth accumulation, and segregation in the United States, the disinvested areas where gentrification takes place are often (though not always) neighborhoods of color, and the relatively wealthy newcomers are often (though not always) white (for a review that teases out these dynamics, see Golio 2024). This form of 'white influx' gentrification was become more common since the year 2000 (Freeman and Cai 2015; Hyra 2017; Sutton 2020). When gentrifying neighborhoods come to embody a 'white space' (Anderson 2015), structured by white norms of interaction, people of color may feel alienated from this new dominant social environment and the spatial repressions it engenders (Doering 2020; Monroe Sullivan & Shaw 2011).

Summing up much of this previous research, Rucks-Ahidiana (2022) posits that gentrification is a process of racial capitalism – meaning that the process either advances or stagnates through the ascription of racialized value onto people, institutions, or neighborhoods (see also Dantzler 2021). White-serving aesthetics, social amenities, and institutions (i.e., those that make up the 'white space'), therefore, may be more highly valued and prioritized in this process (Golio 2024). Those that serve people of color, on the other hand, might be either displaced or else appropriated into this schema (Hyra 2017; Summers 2019). My findings fit into this perspective –

I identify that the social amenity perspective on gentrification appears to be exclusive to white residents, while those of color report no such benefit.

III. *Conceptualizing Community*

Sociological concern over community interaction, trust, and embeddedness has been a perennial theme since the founding of the discipline. As it turns out, however, 'community' is a difficult concept to define and operationalize. It is a socially constructed idea that depends on the perceptions of group members (Sampson 2012; Suttles 1972). Individuals may perceive themselves as part of a 'community' – and this is what makes it a community. My analysis straddles this definition: some of my quantitative measures capture discrete levels of participation, while others query respondents for their perception of their surroundings and neighbors, and the extent to which they believe these constitute a cohesive community. Here, I identify a few specific sociological concepts that are relevant to my data and analysis – without drawing out an extensive debate on exactly which factors make for a strong 'community' life.

Most simply, we could define community in terms of social ties – points of connection amongst people. Social network analysts will have much more to say about ties' strength, structure, and their ability to serve as 'bridges' that make certain outcomes possible. For my purposes, it is sufficient to point out that both relatively strong kinship and friend ties as well as relatively weak or temporary acquaintance ties are significant for social support and advancement (Deckard and Auyero 2022; Desmond 2012; Granovetter 1973; Small 2017; Stack 1983).

In addition to ties, community might be measured in terms of social cohesion, or perception of membership in a social group (Friedkin 2004). As applied to a neighborhood, then, cohesion refers to the extent to which residents perceive that their neighbors form a meaningful group

beyond merely proximity to one another (Forrest and Kearns 2001). Therefore, social cohesion typically encompasses feelings of interconnectedness, trust, and reciprocity (Chan, To, and Chan 2006; Schiefer and van der Noll 2017). Building further, collective efficacy describes both neighbors' perception of social cohesion plus their shared sense of social control and a willingness to intervene on behalf of others (Sampson, Raudenbush, and Earls 1997).[2]

There are a myriad of individual- and group-level factors that impact one's ability to form ties, one's perception of social cohesion and collective efficacy, and one's proclivity to participate in neighborhood affairs. Several of these will appear as control variables in my regression analysis. Most pertinent to my focus on gentrification, however, is how spatial context shapes these various aspects of community life. The logic behind 'neighborhood effects' is that all manner of social outcomes are spatially clustered within an urban landscape, making local context sociologically meaningful for analysis (Sampson 2012). No different from many other outcomes, social life is also spatially dependent, and the strength of community varies across neighborhoods (Logan 2012; Sampson 2012; Small and Adler 2019). Where the neighborhood effects literature is primarily focused on the persistence and durability of spatial differences (Sampson 2012), here I look at what happens to perceptions and participation in the context of neighborhood change, as demographics and real estate shift.

Data and Methods

I. *Data: 2013 American Housing Survey*

[2] Social capital is a familiar concept that is closely related to those outlined above. However, as suggested in its title, social capital is typically conceived as more of a resource that arises from social ties (Coleman 1988; Putnam 2000). In my analysis, I use ties, cohesion and collective efficacy because these are the concepts that best fit my data. I observe the extent to which neighbors interact and respondents' perceptions of neighborhood trust and control, but cannot observe how these are parlayed as resources or capital.

My source of individual-level information is the 2013 round of the American Housing Survey (AHS). I selected 2013 because it is the only survey year that includes a battery of questions related to neighborhood social and political life. The AHS is a national, biennial survey of housing units and the people that occupy them, carried out collaboratively by the U.S. Census Bureau and U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development. Observations within the AHS are represented as 'households' rather than individual respondents. Most demographic variables, such as age or sex, describe the characteristics of the 'householder,' or a reference person for the household. The actual survey respondent may or may not be the householder. As my analysis hinges on variables related to respondents' individual actions or opinions and relates these to demographic information describing the householder, I limit my working sample only to those observations wherein the respondent is also the householder – ~121,000 of ~168,000 original observations.

I used a confidential version of the AHS to ascertain each respondent's census tract. As is common practice in urban sociological research, I use the census tract to approximate a 'neighborhood,' and use these terms interchangeably. To connect individual AHS respondents with information on their surrounding neighborhood, I use publicly available census tract-level data from the 2000 Decennial Census and 2009-2013 American Community Survey (ACS) 5-Year Estimates. Via Social Explorer, I downloaded 2000 Census data that were reprojected to match the 2010 census tract boundaries.

I further limited my sample to ~91,500 respondents that reside in populated urban census tracts, here defined as tracts that 1.) have a total population in year 2000 of at least 200 residents, 2.) are located within a metropolitan area (or MSA, metropolitan statistical area), and 3.) have at least 50% of the tract's population located inside an urbanized area (Rucks-Ahidiana 2021). I only use urban census tracts for two reasons. First, though some researchers study rural gentrification

processes (i.e., Brown-Saracino 2009), gentrification is typically thought of as a process that takes place in urban areas (Smith 1998:198). Second, census tracts only functionally approximate 'neighborhoods' within a city, as the geographical boundaries of tracts are drawn to capture a certain number of residents and therefore vary in area based on population density.

Next, I limited my sample to ~36,000 respondents with valid, non-missing responses to each variable in my models. The set of questions related to 'neighborhood social capital' were surveyed on a random, rotating basis to only about a third of all AHS households. This explains the large number of missing values.

Finally, my working sample includes only the ~17,500 respondents that reside in neighborhoods that were 'gentrifiable' in the year 2000. Following standard theory and methodology (Ding, Hwang, and Divringi 2016; Freeman 2005; Hwang and Sampson 2014), gentrifiable neighborhoods are those with a year 2000 tract-level median household income that ranks in the lower half of all urban tracts within the same MSA. These tracts are 'eligible' to gentrify, as gentrification is typically conceived of as a process that impacts relatively low-income and historically disinvested areas (Smith 1998:198). The ~17,500 respondents in my working sample reside in ~9,000 different census tracts across ~200 American metropolitan areas.

In various multi-group analyses, I also divide these respondents into distinct sub-samples in order to observe differences in groups based on race, income, and residency length. For race, groups are based on respondents' self-identified racial categorization: non-Hispanic white, non-Hispanic Black, or Latinx (i.e., Hispanic).[3] For income, I divide respondents into quartiles based on self-reported yearly household income, as compared to other respondents in the same MSA. For residency length, I divide respondents into quartiles based on the self-reported number of years

[3] No other racial category accounted for enough respondents to form a group large enough to pass Census Bureau disclosure requirements. Residents that do not fall into one of these categories are excluded.

occupying their current dwelling (obtained by subtracting their move-in year from 2013), as compared to other respondents in the same MSA.

II. *Dependent Variables: Social Assessment and Political Participation*

My dependent variables are based around the 21 'neighborhood social capital' variables from the 2013 AHS, which I use to model various aspects of community life. I combine these individual survey items into latent constructs, guided by a principal component analysis conducted by Li and Zhang (2021). Based on their work, I employ 6 latent variables as dependent outcomes in my analysis.[4] As I describe in the findings section below, a confirmatory factor analysis shows that these constructs fit the data well.

Two of these constructs measure the respondent's perception of their neighborhood's social environment. *Social cohesion* captures the extent to which the respondent feels that their neighbors form a close-knit, trusting, and congenial community. *Collective efficacy* aligns closely with Sampson, Raudenbush, and Earls' (1997) original conception of the attribute. It measures the respondent's perception of informal social control within their neighborhood, in terms of how likely they believe it is that a neighbor would intervene in several unsavory situations.

Two constructs measure the respondent's self-reported levels of social interaction and participation. *Social ties* surveys respondents on how often they interact with their neighbors, and how many of them they would consider to be friends. Therefore, the latent construct captures the local prevalence of both relatively close friendship ties and 'weak' acquaintance ties. *Civic*

[4] I apply one minor alteration to Li and Zhang's (2021) latent constructs. They include a seventh component called 'Religious Organizational Involvement,' which consists of only 1 survey item. This would not work well with my analytic methods of structural equation modeling, so I instead place this item under 'civic participation.'

participation evaluates the respondent's involvement or membership in social/fraternal, service, or religious organizations.

The final two constructs measure the respondent's self-reported political involvement. *Informal political participation* assesses the respondent's engagement in interpersonal problem-solving efforts, like speaking to neighbors or a local religious leader about neighborhood improvement. *Formal political participation*, on the other hand, measures whether or not the respondent has engaged with more formalized mechanisms of problem-solving, like neighborhood meetings, community councils, or elected officials. I recoded all indicators such that '1' indicates the most negative response (i.e., 'strongly disagree' or 'no') and the highest number indicates the most positive response (i.e., 'strongly agree' or 'yes').[5]

III. *Focal Independent Variable: Gentrification*

Most quantitative studies of gentrification measure the process as a binary variable. Typically, researchers observe a set of tract-level indicators at time *T1* and then again at time *T2*, and if the differences meet certain pre-determined thresholds, then the neighborhood has 'gentrified' (i.e., Ding, Hwang, and Divringi 2016; Freeman 2005; Hammel and Wyly 1996; Lee and Perkins 2023; Rucks-Ahidiana 2021). The categorical-threshold measure is useful for simplification, and for direct comparison. Theoretically, however, gentrification is not thought of as a binary state of being, but as a *process* that can be observed at many different stages (Smith 1998:198). Here, I use structural equation modeling to create a continuous measure of gentrification and incorporate it into regression models. I view gentrification itself as a latent variable, comprised of several observed indicators that load onto a single factor.

[5] For further information on AHS survey items, including survey prompt and measurement scale, reference the online AHS codebook at https://www.census.gov/data-tools/demo/codebook/ahs/ahsdict.html. I keep all variable names (i.e., in Figure 1) the same.

To create this measure, I borrow the 4 observed indicators used by Rucks-Ahidiana (2021), based on previous efforts by Ding, Hwang, and Divringi (2016), Freeman (2005), and others: change in the tract-level proportion of residents over the age of 25 with a college degree, change in the tract-level median household income (MHHI), change in tract-level median gross rent, and change in tract-level median home value.[6] I measure change in each indicator between 2000 and 2013 using the aforementioned Decennial Census and ACS data.[7]

It is important to measure tract-level changes relative to the metropolitan area in which the tract is located. Without this step, it is possible that observed tract-level changes are due to shifts in the broader urban context, rather than neighborhood-level gentrification. In order to capture MSA-relative changes in my four indicators, I borrow methodology developed by Lee and Perkins (2023). I first put each urban census tract within a given MSA into rank order from lowest to highest based on each indicator's value in the year 2000, and then divide by the total number of census tracts in the MSA to obtain a relative percentile. I then re-rank each tract in 2013 to obtain a new set of relative percentiles, and observe the differences. For example, if Tract 1 within City A ranks at the 20th percentile (0.2) in terms of median gross rent in 2000, and then ranks in the 40th percentile (0.4) in 2013, this indicates that Tract 1's surge in rent prices has outpaced growth in other tracts in City A. This gain of 20 percentiles (0.2) will positively influence Tract 1's overall gentrification score, along with similar measures of MSA-relative changes in college education

[6] Note that all dollar values are adjusted for inflation to 2013 values.

[7] In the Census and ACS, home value is self-reported by homeowner respondents, and therefore possibly subject to measurement error (Benítez-Silva et al. 2015). However, all four gentrification measures load strongly onto a single factor in confirmatory factor analyses, indicating that despite some estimation error, all of them are likely to rise and fall in tandem. Further, even if homeowners are not always the best judges of value, there are few unproblematic and systematic data alternatives to estimate home value. Assessor's Office data, for instance, would have to obtained from every individual municipality or county, and even then, is subject to its own forms of error, particularly in racially marginalized communities. Given a lack of options and strong model fit, I use the self-reported home value measure.

percentile, MHHI percentile, and median housing value percentile. These 4 indicators load strongly onto a single gentrification variable (see Figure 1).

IV. *Control Independent Variables*

A number of individual-level factors are also likely associated with a respondent's social assessments and participation. I include several in my models as control variables: *Homeownership* is often noted as one of the most important factors for neighborhood satisfaction and involvement, as homeowners are often thought to be more 'invested' in their neighborhoods than renters are (Grinstein-Weiss et al. 2011; Li and Zhang 2021). I therefore include a binary measure of homeownership from the AHS, wherein '1' indicates the respondent owns and '0' indicates they rent or otherwise occupy. I also include a binary measure on whether or not the respondent has a *walking disability*, which could hamper their ability to fully participate in community life.

Various socioeconomic and demographic characteristics are also found to be important indicators (Li and Zhang 2021; Parkes, Kearns, and Atkinson 2002). I therefore include a continuous measure of *age* and series of categorical variables for *race* (non-Hispanic white, non-Hispanic Black, non-Hispanic Asian, Latinx, and other) and *sex* (male or female; other options are not provided in the AHS). I measure *household income* as a categorical ordinal variable, dividing respondents into quartiles based on respondents' self-reported yearly household income as compared to other AHS respondents in the same MSA. In multi-group regression models based on either race or income, I do not include that corresponding set of control variables.

V. *Analytic Method: Structural Equation Modeling*

I utilize a structural equation modeling (SEM) approach as a general framework for my regression analyses. SEM is an ideal technique for analysis that includes the construction of latent variables, as it combines the logics of both confirmatory factor analysis and regression-style estimation to predict a comprehensive model (Bollen 1989). SEM also allows me to specify several multivariate relationships – therefore, all six of my dependent variables can be estimated in one model. Structural equation models are typically visually represented as path diagrams, rather than as a series of equations. The nodes in each diagram represent variables: ovals depict latent variables, while rectangles are observed variables. Arrows connecting these nodes indicate the relationship that is being estimated.

My analytic models utilize indicators contained within the 2013 AHS, 2000 Decennial Census, and 2009-2013 ACS as either observed variables or as indicators that make up the aforementioned community life and gentrification latent variables. I analyze my conceptual models using the *lavaan* package in *R* (Rosseel 2012). All of my models utilize diagonally weighted least squares (DWLS) regression estimators, which are standard for SEM models that use ordinal variables, and tend to be more accurate than maximum likelihood estimators (Li 2016). The *lavaan* package also allows for multi-group SEM analysis, in which a path model is tested simultaneously amongst multiple groups within a sample (Jöreskog 1971; Sorböm 1974).[8]

Findings

I. *Descriptive Results*

I begin my analysis by looking more in depth at the dependent and independent variables that make

[8] I also considered using a multilevel SEM approach, with respondents nested within either census tracts or metropolitan areas. However, diagnostic statistics on these models, such as the intraclass correlation coefficient (ICC), demonstrated a lack of justification for a multilevel approach.

up my analytic structural equation models. First, to ensure that my measurement model of 7 latent variables fits the data well, I performed a confirmatory factor analysis (CFA). Figure 1 presents a path diagram depicting the variable relationships and factor loading coefficients for each latent variable and its exogenous components, predicted using the full sample of ~17,500 respondents from lower-income urban neighborhoods. As is typical within CFA model estimation, the first path coefficient for each latent variable is fixed at 1; for the others, a value closer to 1 indicates an observed item that is more closely related to the latent variable and first item. For this and each subsequent model I also report a series of statistics related to fit. All models fall well within standard acceptable ranges. For graphic simplicity, I do not include error depictions alongside each observed variable. [FIGURE 1 HERE]

Overall, Figure 1 demonstrates a strong measurement model, with all observed variables significantly predicted by the latent constructs. Guiding authors typically suggest that factor loadings should reach at least 0.5 for interpretation purposes, though greater than 0.7 is preferable and ideal (Stevens 2009). All path coefficients reach this first threshold, and all but one reach the second. Given these affirming results, I move forward into analytic regression with this latent variable measurement model.

After observing how the observed survey items fit the latent variable constructs within the data, I also wanted to get a sense of the relationship amongst the six dependent socio-political variables. To this end, I used the *lavaan* package to estimate the implied latent variable correlations based on the measurement model depicted in Figure 1. Using the *corrplot* package in R, I arranged the model-implied correlations for the six socio-political latent variables into a matrix, depicted in Figure 2. This visual makes it apparent that there are two distinct clusters of variables. The first cluster depicts strong correlations amongst social experience variables – particularly, respondents'

perceptions of social cohesion and collective efficacy. The second cluster, depicted in the bottom right-hand corner of Figure 2, demonstrates that the three forms of neighborhood participation (civic, informal political, and formal political) are closely correlated. Social ties is moderately correlated with all other latent variables, and therefore does not fall clearly into one cluster or the other. Conceptually, I place it within the 'social environment' category rather than the 'political participation' category. Given these clusters, when assessing the overall relationship between gentrification and social environment (i.e., parsing between the social displacement vs. social amenity perspectives), I look to coefficients related to cohesion, efficacy, and ties. When assessing the overall relationship between gentrification and political participation (i.e., political displacement vs. political mobilization perspectives), I look to coefficients related to civic, informal, and formal participation. [FIGURE 2 HERE]

Finally, before turning to analytic regression results, I report some descriptive statistics on the independent control variables included in the models below. Most of these variables are categorical, and so I provide approximate frequencies for each in Table 1. Due to Census Bureau regulations, I can only report these as rounded figures. Because my sample is limited only to relatively low-income, 'gentrifiable' census tracts, more respondents fall into the lower quartiles in terms of income, and are less likely to be homeowners. The only continuous control variable within the model is respondent age. Within my dataset, the mean age is 49.3 years old, and the median is 48. [TABLE 1 HERE]

II. *Assessing Gentrification and Community Life*

Having assessed the measurement model of latent variables to confirm that it fits the data well, I turn now to include this model in SEM regression analysis. In Figure 3, I present a path analysis

depiction of the primary model with all control variables included. For graphic simplicity and due to Census Bureau disclosure constraints, I do not report the path coefficients amongst observed variables and their latent predictors. These figures do not substantively change – in either strength or significance – from the measurement model in Figure 1 across any of the models below. Also, in the path analysis depiction in Figure 3 I do not include control variable paths and coefficients – this would result in a diagram that is far too complicated to easily identify results. Instead, I include all path coefficients, along with their standard errors, in Table 3. [FIGURE 3 HERE]

This initial model reveals positive, statistically significant associations between neighborhood gentrification and both satisfaction with the social environment and local political participation. Amongst all urban respondents from lower-income neighborhoods, therefore, we can observe initial evidence for the social amenity and political mobilization hypotheses. As neighborhood gentrification intensifies, respondents' assessments of the social environment tend to grow more positive, and they tend to engage more with local civic, social, and political life. Here, gentrification appears to be most closely associated with respondents' political participation, both formal and informal, along with their formation of social ties. [TABLE 3 HERE]

In terms of control variables, most patterns align with findings in previous literature. Generally, racial minorities, those with lower household incomes, and those with disabilities have more negative assessments of the neighborhood social environment and are less likely to participate in local affairs than their white, higher-income, and non-disabled peers. This should generally be attributed to racist, classist, and ableist structural biases in the formation of urban environments, like racial segregation and concurrent disinvestment in neighborhoods of color. One exception to this pattern is that Black respondents are more likely than white respondents to be involved in civic organizations and political activism. Respondents tend to participate more and

are more satisfied with the social environment as they grow older, and homeowners demonstrate clear advantages over renters in all categories, as expected. Sex has minor bearing on some factors – for instance, women are more likely to participate in civic and formal political organizations. These control variable results generally hold across the multi-group models in the section below.

III. *Differences Across Racial, Income and Residency Length Groups*

The general trends presented in the previous section depict relationships amongst all respondents in lower-income urban neighborhoods. As reviewed, however, scholars often express particular concern for certain vulnerable populations, like low-income residents, long-timers, and racial minorities, and how they fare in gentrifying settings. In this section, therefore, I use multi-group SEM to split respondents based on these three categories, and observe how the associations differ.

I begin with income, dividing respondents into 4 quartile groups based on yearly household income, as compared to other respondents in the same MSA. Figure 4 depicts a series of path diagrams, each representing the focal relationships and regression path coefficients for one income group. Control variables are included in this model, save for income level as this is instead used as grouping criteria. Once again, I have simplified the graphic representation of the path diagram by removing the measurement model paths amongst latent variables and their observed variable predictors. These have not changed from Figures 1 and 3. [FIGURE 4 HERE]

For all dependent variables, the strongest positive associations with gentrification generally appear amongst the two lower-income groups. Save for social ties and formal participation, significant relationships entirely disappear amongst the highest earners. This is surprising – based on previous theory, we might expect gentrification to be *least* well-received amongst poorer individuals. What I propose, however, is that understanding these findings requires an expansion

of focus. Neighborhood inequality – solidified over many years of municipal practice and uneven development – structures the urban environment such that working-class areas have, generally, lower levels of social cohesion and community participation. This holds up in my data as well: estimated latent variable values for all 6 socio-political indicators are much lower amongst those in lower-income neighborhoods, as compared to those in higher-income neighborhoods. Therefore, it could be that gentrification has less of a positive impact on social life amongst higher-income respondents because their satisfaction and participation are already relatively high.

Next, I group respondents by length of residency, using an MSA-relative quartile approach similar to the income groups. Figure 5 provides the results for focal relationships with controls included. Here, the results align more closely with what we might expect. It is the newest residents – those who have lived in their dwellings for the shortest periods of time – who report the strongest positive associations with gentrification in terms of social environment. These relationships are either much weaker or disappear entirely amongst the longest-term residency groups. The gentrification process often involves the addition of commercial and recreational amenities that cater toward in-movers, and therefore it makes sense that we would see positive evaluations from this group – but not necessarily amongst long-time residents. [FIGURE 5 HERE]

In terms of political participation, we find something of the opposite. The association between gentrification and informal means of neighborhood problem-solving is strongest amongst the longest-tenured residents, and there is no relationship at all amongst the shortest-tenured. A significant relationship with formal participation, however, exists amongst all groups – a pattern that is strongest amongst the second-longest group, but is nonetheless fairly strong across the board. We therefore observe a consistent association: as gentrification intensifies, residents become more politically active and engaged. Informal participation, which happens amongst

neighbors, may be easier for those who have lived in their homes longer and have had more time to establish relationships, where formal mechanisms might be more accessible to newcomers.

Finally, I turn to examine residents grouped according to racial identity. Focal results are depicted in Figure 6. Immediately apparent is that the social amenity perspective (significant, positive associations between gentrification and social environment variables) only applies to white residents, for the most part. The Black racial group retains a strong relationship with social ties only, and all significant associations disappear amongst Latinx residents. Racial minority groups, therefore, do not report higher levels of cohesion or efficacy as gentrification intensifies – even though their white peers do. Positive associations amongst gentrification and informal and formal forms of political participation, however, can be observed across all racial groups. Both of these associations are strongest amongst white residents, but hold generally across Black and Latinx groups as well. [FIGURE 6 HERE]

Discussion and Conclusion

Does gentrification represent a social amenity for the communities in which it takes place, or does it lead to social displacement? Politically, do residents engage or disengage when urban change takes place? Using data from the 2013 AHS, I demonstrate that the answers to these questions are complex yet distinctly patterned, split along a number of familiar axes related to social location. In this final section, I review my findings, further contextualize them, and point toward remaining questions and areas of debate.

Amongst all focal respondents, I find some support for the social amenity perspective – and find that lower-income residents tend to report the strongest positive associations between levels of neighborhood cohesion and gentrification. Given previous theoretical insight on the

deleterious social impacts of gentrification on working-class communities, this result might strike some as surprising. Instead of throwing away these previous conceptions, however, I believe that my findings make more sense when contextualized in terms of the detrimental social impacts of neighborhood-level inequality and concentrated poverty. Reflecting the work of scholars like Wilson (1987) and Sampson (2012), I find that typical rates of social satisfaction are much lower in relatively low-income urban neighborhoods, as compared to those in higher-income areas. This could be due to income-based inequities in ability to participate in activities and organizations – wealth generally affords more free time for such things. But these differences could also be attributed to structural and spatial inequalities in institutional investment of community-sustaining institutions. In a helpful schematic, Golash-Boza (2023) points out in disadvantaged neighborhoods – particularly those that are racially marginalized – resources are invested in carceral responses to social problems, like policing, prisons, and other institutions that shatter a sense of community rather than build it. Meanwhile, whiter and wealthier neighborhoods receive life-sustaining investments in education, community-building, and employment opportunities. Perhaps, in the early stages of gentrification, local residents are happy to receive some of these forms of investment, driving influence over gentrification as a social amenity.

But this perspective also has limits. The extent to which gentrification serves as a social amenity is tempered according to race and length of residency. It is amongst newer residents and white respondents that we find the strongest positive associations between gentrification and social environment. To varying degrees, these relationships either disappear from statistical significance entirely or are substantially weakened amongst longer-term residents and racial minority groups. These results beg us to return to a question posed by Danley and Weaver (2018): who are contemporary, gentrified cities built for? Like other scholars, I identify that in gentrifying areas,

the needs of long-time residents are not as likely to be prioritized, and amenities are geared more toward the interests of newcomers. It also appears that dominant forms of gentrification reflect the favored aesthetics and norms of interaction of white residents, as scholars like Summers (2019) and Helmuth (2019) have pointed out. Gentrification can enhance the proliferation of 'white space' (Anderson 2015), in which people of color feel alienated by microaggressions and dominant, white-centric forms of interaction. While I do not find evidence of social displacement in my data, it does appear that there are forms of gentrification-related community-building that people of color are excluded from. I find validation for a burgeoning literature that seeks to measure and theorize gentrification as a racialized process, and encourage more work in this field in order to better understand these racially disparate results. In an age of widespread gentrification in settings across the US, it is important to understand who is left out of community development and why.

My results indicate broad support for the political mobilization perspective. As opposed to the social environment variables, respondents within all social location groups report strong positive associations between gentrification and political participation. As neighborhood gentrification intensifies, residents of all stripes tend to become more involved in local affairs and problem-solving efforts. There are some differences in terms of *how* people participate – for instance, higher-income and shorter-term residents seem to gravitate toward formal means of participation like neighborhood meetings while lower-income and longer-term residents report more informal means like interpersonal conversation with neighbors. This might reflect the dynamics of who is afforded greater access to certain types of influence. Regardless, the results draw attention to the multi-faceted and diverse ways that everyday people seek to assert agency and maintain control over the broad social forces that shape their environment.

This agency has not received as much attention in the literature on gentrification as the

factors that drive and perpetuate gentrification. In a 2016 piece that lays out an agenda for gentrification research, Brown-Saracino highlights several underexplored areas, and dedicates a section to 'resistance.' She notes that scholars should aim to produce more work on "everyday actors' concerns, and of interventions they seek to make" (Brown-Saracino 2016:223). More generally, sociology as a discipline often suffers from the same deficit: extensive focus on the structures that shape peoples' lives and perpetuate inequality, but relatively little focus on how people try to shape these structures in turn. My findings provide validation for such interventions in the literature. I have identified that across contexts and social groups, gentrification is associated with political mobilization. Qualitative research or more fine-grained survey assessments could be used to further identify what this mobilization looks like, its effectiveness, and what residents want from urban change. This will require getting involved with and observing not just the highly vocal and visible activists that sociologists tend to gravitate toward. I show here that many participate in informal, interpersonal ways – requiring us to also think more about how everyday people show up as well.

Sociologists have long maintained concern over the strength of communities, and the trust, belonging, and meaningful social interaction present amongst those who live in proximity. In this paper, I have investigated these concerns in the context of gentrification, a major phenomenon shaping a large number of American communities. I find, most significantly, that these concerns reflect lines of social demarcation – particularly, in terms of the racialized impact of urban development. I have done this by attempting to bridge a noted methodological divide (Brown-Saracino 2017), taking a largely qualitative concept and modeling it quantitatively. In doing so, I provide a cross-context glimpse into the extent of socio-political impacts related to gentrification, and also a needed lens on stratification across social groups. It is my hope that both scholars and

urban practitioners will continue to include these considerations in future work on community, cohesion, and participation.

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Table 1. Approximate Frequencies for Independent Control Variables

Variable	Category	Number	Percent
Race	White	8,000	45.7%
	Black	4,300	24.6%
	Latinx	3,700	21.1%
	Asian	700	4.0%
	Other	550	3.1%
Income Quartile	Lowest	6,300	36.0%
	Mid-Low	5,200	29.7%
	Mid-High	3,700	21.1%
	Highest	2,200	12.6%
Disability Status	Disability	1,800	10.3%
	No Disability	15,500	88.6%
Homeownership	Homeowner	7,600	43.4%
	Renter / Other	9,800	56.0%
Sex	Male	8,000	45.7%
	Female	9,400	53.7%

N	17,500

Note: Due to approximations required by the Census Bureau, category frequencies will not equal 17,500 and percentages will not equal 100%

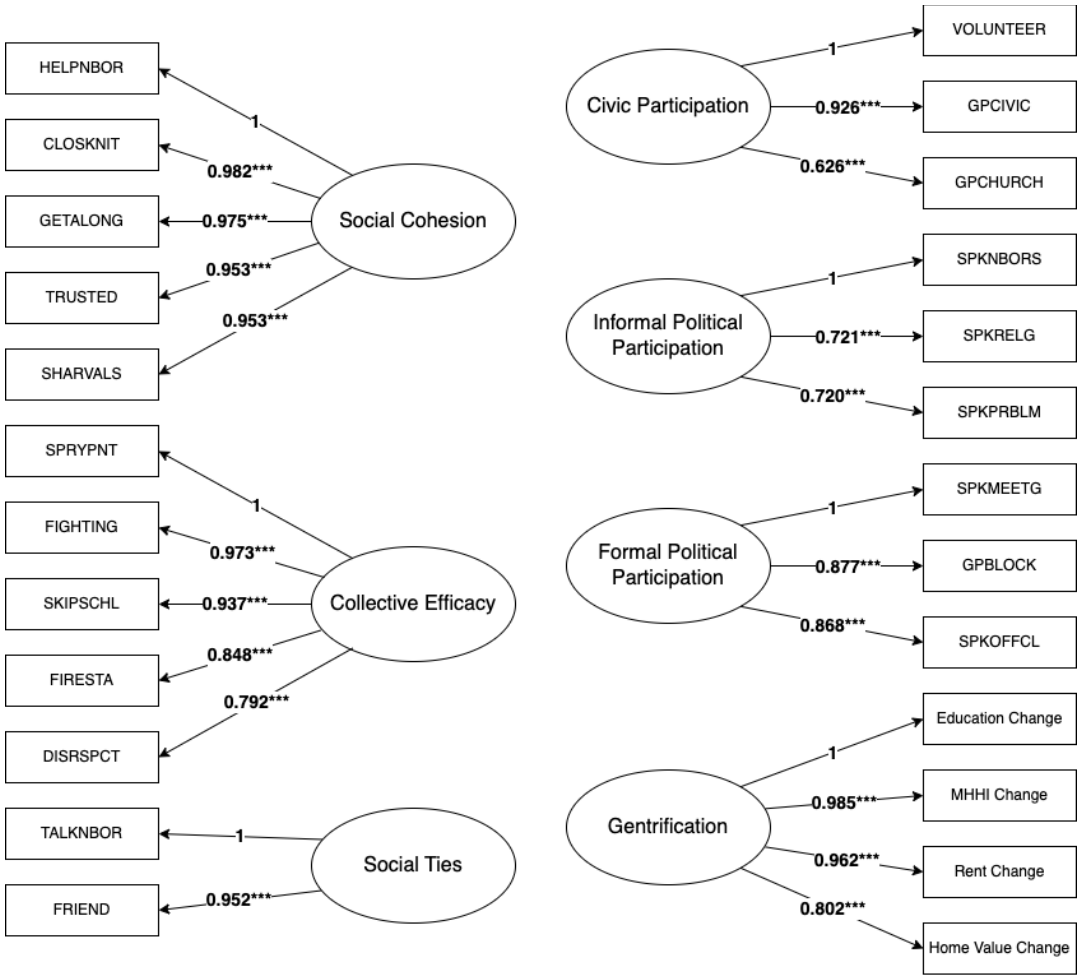
Table 2. Full Regression Estimates from Full Sample Structural Equation Model (Figure 3)

	Dependent Variable					
	Cohesion	**Efficacy**	**Ties**	**Civic**	**Informal**	**Formal**
Gentrification	0.514***	0.368***	0.859***	0.321*	0.799***	1.296***
	(0.102)	(0.101)	(0.111)	(0.13)	(0.156)	(0.151)
Race: Black	-0.140***	-0.067***	-0.134***	0.216***	0.276***	0.190***
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.02)	(0.023)	(0.027)	(0.026)
Race: Asian	-0.019	-0.140***	-0.187***	-0.249***	-0.282***	-0.25***
	(0.039)	(0.038)	(0.039)	(0.048)	(0.063)	(0.058)
Race: Latinx	0.005	-0.052**	-0.035	-0.206***	-0.126***	-0.238***
	(0.019)	(0.019)	(0.021)	(0.025)	(0.031)	(0.03)
Race: Other	-0.149***	-0.074	-0.059	0.068	0.104	0.019
	(0.04)	(0.039)	(0.043)	(0.05)	(0.059)	(0.058)
Mid-Low Income	0.041*	0.052**	0.011	0.14***	-0.033	0.036
	(0.018)	(0.018)	(0.02)	(0.023)	(0.029)	(0.027)

Mid-High Income	0.113*** (0.021)	0.133*** (0.021)	0.041 (0.022)	0.268*** (0.026)	0.065* (0.032)	0.206*** (0.03)
High Income	0.186*** (0.026)	0.233*** (0.026)	0.165*** (0.027)	0.489*** (0.031)	0.178*** (0.038)	0.402*** (0.035)
Age	0.008*** (0.00)	0.005*** (0.00)	0.01*** (0.001)	0.005*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.01*** (0.001)
Disability	-0.069** (0.024)	-0.081** (0.024)	-0.035 (0.027)	-0.096** (0.032)	0.032 (0.036)	-0.033 (0.034)
Homeowner	0.218*** (0.017)	0.212*** (0.017)	0.265*** (0.018)	0.269*** (0.021)	0.327*** (0.025)	0.437*** (0.024)
Female	-0.053*** (0.015)	-0.001 (0.015)	-0.021 (0.016)	0.118*** (0.018)	0.004 (0.022)	0.072** (0.021)
CFI	0.987					
TLI	0.992					
RMSEA	0.035					
SRMR	0.041					

Note: N = ~17,500; reference category for race is white, for income is low income, for disability is 'no,' for homeowner is renter, and for sex is male; * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure 1. Confirmatory Factor Analysis Path Diagram Depicting Latent Variable Fit



N = ~17,500; CFI = 0.991; TLI = 0.990; RMSEA = 0.041; SRMR = 0.043
*** indicates $p < 0.001$

Figure 2. Correlation Matrix of Model-Implied Values Amongst Latent Socio-Political Variables, N = ~17,500

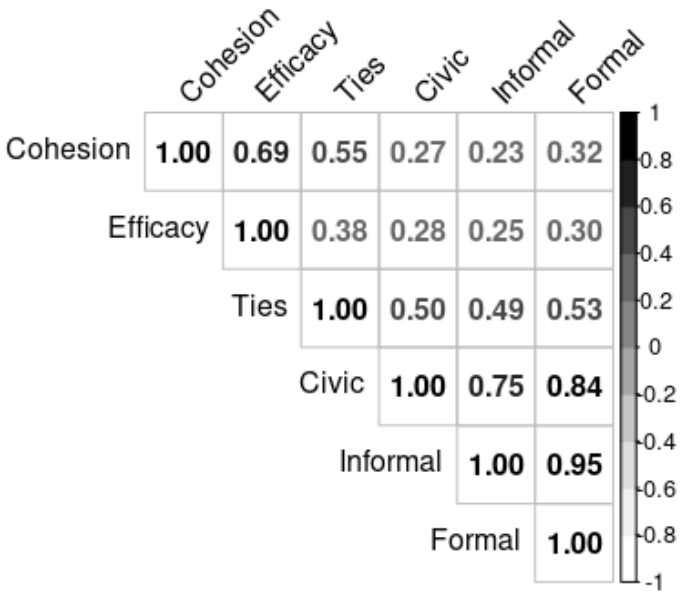
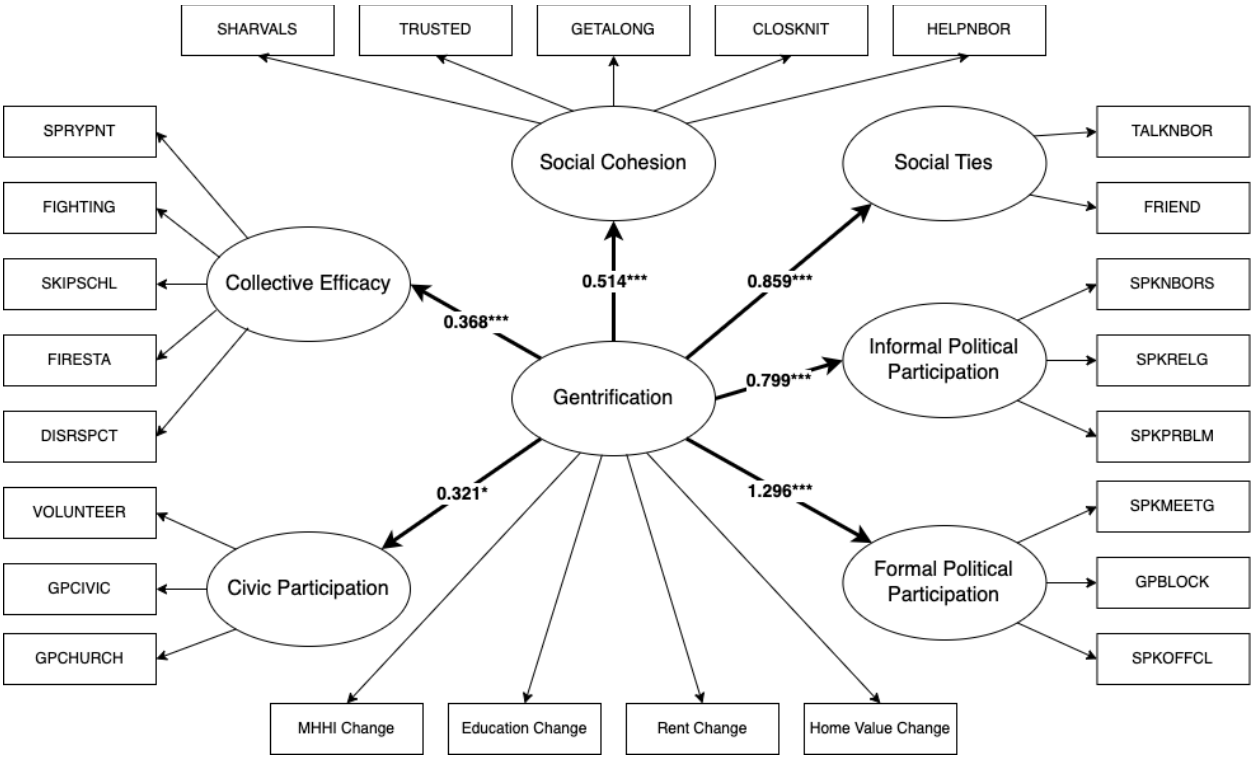


Figure 3. Structural Equation Model with Full Sample and Control Variables



N = ~17,500; CFI = 0.987; TLI = 0.992; RMSEA = 0.035; SRMR = 0.041

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure 4. Multi-Group Structural Equation Model by MSA-Relative Household Income Quartile, with Control Variables



CFI = 0.988; TLI = 0.991; RMSEA = 0.036; SRMR = 0.044

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure 5. Multi-Group Structural Equation Model by MSA-Relative Length of Residency Quartile, with Control Variables



CFI = 0.988; TLI = 0.992; RMSEA = 0.034; SRMR = 0.044

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Figure 6. Multi-Group Structural Equation Model by Respondent Racial Self-Categorization



CFI = 0.989; TLI = 0.992; RMSEA = 0.035; SRMR = 0.048

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$